Module 2, Lesson 2.3: Your First Conversation

The Moment of Truth

You've installed OpenClaw. You've configured it. Now it's time for the real test: actually talking to your AI agent.

This lesson isn't just about having a conversation—it's about learning to communicate effectively with an AI that has memory, tools, and the ability to act on your behalf. Think of it as learning a new language, except this language is about clarity, context, and collaboration.

Starting Your First Session

Open your terminal and start OpenClaw:

```
openclaw chat
```

You'll see a prompt indicating your agent is ready. Now let's have that first conversation.

Conversation 1: The Introduction

You: "Hello! Introduce yourself and tell me how you can help me."

Agent: (Will respond based on your IDENTITY.md and SOUL.md configuration)

This is a good first prompt because:

- It tests your agent's identity configuration
- It establishes the working relationship

- It gives you a baseline for how your agent communicates

Pro Tip: Pay attention to the response. Does it match the personality you configured? If not, you may need to adjust your IDENTITY.md or SOUL.md files.

Conversation 2: The Memory Test

You: "Remember this: I'm working on launching a consulting business focused on AI automation for small businesses. This is my priority project for the next 6 months."

Agent: "I'll remember that. You're launching an AI automation consulting business for small businesses, and it's your priority for the next 6 months. I've noted this in my memory."

This tests:

- Your agent's memory functionality
- Its ability to store important information
- Its confirmation that it understood correctly

Verify it worked: "Let's test your memory. What am I working on for the next 6 months?"

If configured correctly, your agent should recall the consulting business without hesitation.

Conversation 3: The Tool Test

You: "Create a file in my workspace called project-notes.md with a header that says 'AI Automation Consulting Business' and add three bullet points for things I should focus on this week."

Agent: (Ideally creates the file and adds thoughtful suggestions)

This tests:

- File creation capabilities
- Writing permissions
- Ability to generate relevant content
- Following multi-step instructions

Check the file was created:

```
cat ~/.openclaw/workspace/project-notes.md
```

Learning to Communicate with AI Agents

Effective AI communication is different from human conversation. Here are the principles:

Principle 1: Be Specific, Not Vague

Vague: "Help me with my business."

Specific: "I'm launching an AI automation consulting business targeting small businesses with 5-50 employees. Help me brainstorm services I could offer and pricing models."

The second prompt gives your agent:

- Clear context (what kind of business)
- Clear target (small businesses, 5-50 employees)
- Clear task (brainstorm services and pricing)
- Clear output format (implied list)

Principle 2: Provide Context Up Front

Without context: "Write an email to Sarah about the meeting."

With context: "Write a professional but friendly email to Sarah Johnson at Acme Corp confirming our meeting next Tuesday at 2 PM. We'll be discussing their supply chain automation needs. She seemed excited about our initial call, so include a brief mention of the results we achieved for a similar company."

Context enables:

- Appropriate tone

- Relevant content
- Personalization
- Better outcomes

Principle 3: Specify Output Format

Unclear format: “What should I focus on this week?”

Clear format: “Give me a prioritized list of 5 things I should focus on this week for my consulting business launch. Format as a numbered list with brief explanations for each.”

Format requests help:

- Get actionable output
- Save time parsing responses
- Create usable artifacts
- Maintain consistency

Principle 4: Iterate, Don’t Expect Perfection

First attempt: “Create a business plan outline.”

Response: (Provides generic outline)

Iteration: “That’s a good start, but I need it tailored for an AI automation consulting business. Focus on services, pricing, and client acquisition. Make it practical, not academic.”

Better response: (Provides tailored, practical outline)

AI agents improve with feedback. Think of it as collaboration, not one-shot requests.

Building Your Working Relationship

Like any working relationship, your partnership with your AI agent develops over time. Here’s how to accelerate that process:

Share Your Context Early

In your first few sessions, deliberately share:

- Your work situation and goals
- Your preferences and pet peeves
- Your communication style
- Your current projects and priorities

Example prompt: “Before we dive into work, let me give you context about me and what I need. I’m [describe your situation]. I prefer [describe communication style]. My current priorities are [list]. What questions do you have?”

Establish Routines

Create predictable interaction patterns:

Morning Check-in: “Good morning. Give me a quick summary of what’s on my plate today based on what we know.”

End of Day: “Summarize what we accomplished today and what’s on deck for tomorrow.”

Weekly Review: “Let’s do a weekly review. What did we get done? What’s carried over? What should be the priorities for next week?”

Give Feedback Explicitly

When your agent does something well: “That was exactly what I needed. Remember to format reports that way in the future.”

When something isn’t right: “That wasn’t quite what I was looking for. I need [specific correction]. Going forward, [instruction for future].”

Ask for Proactive Behavior

Encourage your agent to take initiative: “If you notice something I should know about—like a deadline I’m forgetting or a better way to do something—please tell me. Don’t wait for me to ask.”

Common First Conversation Patterns

Here are useful patterns to establish in your early sessions:

Pattern 1: The Clarification Check

After giving instructions: “Just to confirm you understand: [rephrase what you asked]. Does that match what I’m asking for?”

This catches misunderstandings early.

Pattern 2: The Step-by-Step

For complex tasks: “Let’s break this down. First, [step 1]. Then [step 2]. Check with me before moving to [step 3].”

This gives you checkpoints to verify progress.

Pattern 3: The Draft-and-Refine

For content creation: “Create a first draft of [document type]. I’ll review it, then we can refine together.”

This leverages AI speed while maintaining your quality standards.

Pattern 4: The Devil’s Advocate

For decision-making: “I’m considering [decision]. Play devil’s advocate—what are the strongest arguments against this?”

This surfaces blind spots.

Pattern 5: The Teaching Moment

When learning something new: “I’m trying to understand [topic]. Explain it to me like I’m new to this field, then give me three practical applications.”

This accelerates learning.

What to Expect in Early Sessions

First Week

Your agent will:

- Be learning your preferences and patterns
- Sometimes misunderstand your intent
- Need clarification more often
- Improve with each interaction

You will:

- Be learning how to prompt effectively
- Adjusting your configuration based on experience
- Building shared vocabulary
- Establishing trust

First Month

Your agent will:

- Remember your preferences without asking
- Anticipate your needs more accurately
- Require less clarification
- Handle routine tasks smoothly

You will:

- Trust your agent with more autonomy
- Have established efficient workflows
- Know what to ask for and how
- See real productivity gains

After Three Months

Your agent will:

- Feel like a natural extension of your capabilities
- Handle complex multi-step tasks reliably
- Proactively surface relevant information
- Maintain consistent memory across all sessions

You will:

- Take the assistance for granted (in a good way)
- Have automated significant portions of your work
- Wonder how you ever worked without it

Troubleshooting Common Issues

“My agent doesn’t remember things between sessions”

Check that:

- Memory is enabled in config.yaml
- MEMORY.md exists and is writable
- You’re using the same OpenClaw instance

“My agent’s personality doesn’t match my configuration”

Check that:

- IDENTITY.md and SOUL.md are properly formatted
- Files are in the correct location
- You’ve restarted OpenClaw after changes

“My agent refuses to use tools”

Check that:

- Tools are enabled in config.yaml
- Permissions are properly set
- Paths are accessible

“My agent gives generic responses”

Solutions:

- Add more context to USER.md
- Be more specific in your prompts
- Provide examples of desired output
- Give feedback on responses

Your First Day Action Plan

Here’s a structured approach for your first day working with your AI agent:

Session 1: Setup (15 minutes)

1. Start OpenClaw
2. Introduce yourself and your context
3. Test memory with a key fact
4. Verify tool functionality

Session 2: Exploration (30 minutes)

1. Share your current work situation
2. Ask for suggestions on how it can help
3. Try a few different types of tasks
4. Note what works and what doesn’t

Session 3: Real Work (1 hour)

1. Bring an actual task you need help with

2. Work through it with your agent
3. Iterate on the output
4. Save useful results

End of Day: Review (15 minutes)

1. Summarize what you accomplished
2. Note any configuration changes needed
3. Update USER.md with relevant context
4. Plan tomorrow's first interaction

Coming Up Next

In Lesson 2.4, we'll dive deeper into the memory system—understanding how your AI agent remembers, how to work with its memory effectively, and how to build lasting context that makes every session more productive.

Key Takeaways

1. **First conversations establish the relationship** - Take time to share context and set expectations
2. **Specific prompts get specific results** - Context, format, and clarity matter
3. **Iterate rather than expect perfection** - Feedback improves future responses
4. **Build routines for consistency** - Regular patterns create reliable workflows
5. **The relationship improves over time** - Trust develops through demonstrated competence